PAWS PARTNERS Expert Version — Thinking Hints

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Prefer to discover everything yourself?

The following are general hints about ways to use the mechanisms. Read only the sections that interest you when you get stuck.

1. Work backward from home

What must be true when a friend reaches the last gate? Consider the switch state and where the box or the other friend must be. A friend who goes home before finishing a shared task may no longer be available to help.

2. Separate the first passage from later passages

Some floors change after use. Consider each visit separately: who arrives, and from which direction? Time spent standing on a floor is different from the number of new arrivals on it.

3. Read a turn from both friends' viewpoints

RIGHT and LEFT are relative to the direction a character is travelling.
The same chip may send a friend approaching from another side down a different path. Find shared locations before planning each route alone.

4. Leaving a space empty is a choice

Not every placement space needs a chip. Continuing without turning may be useful. An empty placement does not disable a fixed mechanism underneath, so remember to check that location's picture or label too.

5. Choose where to wait

An equally long wait can have different results before and after releasing the other friend. Ask what event you are waiting for and which state must be preserved until then. More waiting is not always helpful.

6. A box may have several jobs

A box can be an obstruction, a PAD weight, or material for filling a gap.

After finding a useful job for it, ask whether you still need it later.

A resource that is consumed may need to serve another purpose first.

7. Count current PAD weights

If a character leaves but a box remains, the box can keep providing weight.

Some gates may be blocked by extra weight. Check the gate's symbol and work out the required count at the moment of passage. More is not always better.

8. Treat changing and restoring as separate tasks

A change that helps one friend may leave the other unable to proceed.

Ask who needs the change, how long that state is needed, and who will restore it. A detour may be an essential task rather than wasted movement.

9. Observe the first unexpected event

Before replacing every chip, identify where the run first differed from your prediction: a closed gate, an earlier arrival, or a changed floor.

Change one suspected cause and try again to understand the relationship.

10. Use the overview instead of memorizing the map

Use F5 to see homes, gates, switches, and shared routes. Remember dependencies such as preparing one area before passing a gate elsewhere, rather than trying to memorize every step. There is no time limit for planning.

During a run, F5 shows both friends and mechanisms moving on the whole map.

Press Enter to pause and inspect the situation; press Enter again to resume.

F5 returns to the normal view. Esc cancels the run and returns to planning.

11. Write down visits to changing floors

For ALT and CYC, do not plan every future visit from the arrow visible now.

Make one row per arrival: display before arrival / arriving friend / entry direction / exit direction / display after use. This helps you track a floor shared by both friends. Check who needs each visit in the sequence. Simply standing still does not count as another arrival.

12. Making room is another way to help

A route may exist but remain unavailable while the other friend occupies it. For a rocket, check whether its destination is free too. Helping can mean making room or leaving an opportunity unused, as well as opening a route. When investigating a blocked move, consider the other friend's position alongside the floor and gate states.

13. Choose who spends a single use

The first visitor consumes an hourglass or ONE effect. Is it spent before the friend who needs it arrives? Replacing it mentally with WAIT or SWAP can be misleading on the second visit. Plan separately for unused and spent states, and consider leaving an effect available for somebody else.

14. Make a weight schedule

Try columns for event / boxes on PADs / friends on PADs / total. How does each box push, filled hole or departing friend change the count? Opening a gate does not always require adding weight. Count what remains on PADs at that moment, not how many times they have been visited.

15. A different entrance can mean a different exit

A relative turn leads to different exits when approached from different directions. For a species fork, read the effect from each friend's incoming heading instead of guessing from the picture. Sketch who reaches a shared location and from which direction to understand what that location can do.

16. Think before and after, not just longer waits

Separate the event you must wait for from the event you must reach in time. A longer wait may solve one conflict while making another piece of help arrive too late. Pause the F5 overview and examine the first event that differs from your prediction, one cause at a time.

17. A small observation worksheet

Changing floor: visit / friend / entry / display before / exit / display after.

Gate: required condition / who creates it / who can restore it.

Single use: when it must remain unused / who spends it / its later role.

You need not fill out every column. Start with one shared location.

This book contains no stage-by-stage instructions, chip solutions or passwords.

Finally

A short placement sequence can still take a long time to discover. Find a

way for both friends to get home first. There is no need to solve it quickly.